

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

This article appeared on a website:

A daring heart: Meet the bamboo scaffolders of Hong Kong

Intricate bamboo scaffolding is still part of the cityscape in Hong Kong. The metropolis is one of the world's last remaining cities to use bamboo scaffolding in construction and building repair. Luckily, the Construction Industry Council (CIC) and its students are keeping this sustainable skill alive.

Scaffolders perched on bamboo frames several storeys high are a common sight, and are nicknamed 'spiders' by Hong Kong people for their agility over the scaffold. Mo Jia Yu wraps his legs around a pole to balance high above the ground and secure a joint, a skill he must master to become a bamboo scaffolder in Hong Kong. "You have to have a daring heart," says Mo, one of dozens of students who enrol each year at the CIC to learn the traditional method. "You need courage as well as skill to survive," says Professor Chang from the Architecture Department of the University of Hong Kong. "This discourages people from going into the industry."



Despite the dangers involved in the craft, Chang hopes Hong Kong will preserve it as part of its cultural heritage.

Bamboo is readily available across the border in southern Chinese provinces. Its price and efficiency makes it popular, while lightweight bamboo is also easier to transport through a cramped urban centre.

"Bamboo scaffolds are suited to the odd and tight spaces in Hong Kong," adds instructor Kin Kee Wo, who has worked in the construction industry for nearly 30 years. "It can be built in the most unthinkable places, in the most beautiful ways."

Your group is doing a project on bamboo scaffolding. You are meeting to discuss this. You may want to talk about:

- benefits of using bamboo for scaffolding
- ways of improving the safety of bamboo scaffolding
- whether bamboo scaffolding is part of Hong Kong's heritage
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Do you often see bamboo scaffolding in Hong Kong?
2. Would you like to learn to build bamboo scaffolding?
3. Would you like to work in the construction industry in Hong Kong?
4. Are you worried when you have to walk under bamboo scaffolding?
5. Should bamboo scaffolders be paid high salaries?
6. How can bamboo scaffolding be made safer for workers?
7. Should bamboo scaffolding be taught at secondary schools?
8. Do you think people will continue learning traditional crafts?